

Laptop buying advice

We try to simplify the laptop-buying process for you by identifying the essential specs according to your needs

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More people the world over have been buying laptops than desktops, for a couple of years now. With so many different laptop models and endless hardware configurations to choose from, how do you single out the one worthy of purchase? Whether you're a cash-strapped consumer shopping for a notebook PC on a tight budget or an entertainment junkie looking to replace his aging desktop with a powerful all-purpose laptop, in the next couple of pages, we outline some ground rules to remember and abide by when you're researching for your next laptop buy.

Processor

This is the heart and soul of your PC, an important cog to consider. The budget-conscious customer should remember that shopping on a budget isn't without its compromises. You may well desire but can't have the latest and greatest CPU clocked at 2.8 GHz, for it will surely upset your budget. So don't consider the latest Sandy Bridge Intel CPUs, for instance. Older generation laptop CPUs still abound and laptops selling them are often available for a huge discount to clear

of all older stocks and piling inventories. Keep a close eye on retail store offers published in the daily newspaper for a great deal. And since you aren't trying to do a whole lot with an entry-level budget laptop, a dual-core processor clocked at 2 GHz, either from Intel or AMD, should be just fine. To save money even further, we've found that AMD processors are generally cheaper than Intel's - but Intel processors are generally better performers.

For someone interested in buying an all-purpose home laptop, where price envelopes are higher, skip past the latest Intel Core i3-2310M, for instance, and concentrate on purchasing a notebook running on an Intel Core i5-2410M minimum. If you're interested in AMD processors, ignore laptops sporting an AMD Turion X2 and zero in on laptops that have an AMD Phenom II processor, minimum.

RAM

Apart from the processor, the cheapest and best way to get a quick performance boost in any computer is to beef up its system memory or RAM. Most pre-configured laptops these days offer at least 2 GB of RAM - it's pretty much the standard. We recommend upgrading your system memory or RAM from the get-go; don't wait to do so when your system starts getting sluggish a year down the line. If you're having your laptop built to order at a vendor's website, don't hesitate to add extra RAM then and there. If you're buying laptops off the counter at an electronics store, ask for a range that has more than 2 GB of pre-installed RAM. Upgrading to 3 GB or 4 GB may seem like overkill initially, but if you want to hang on to the laptop for a while, that extra memory will be money well spent and keep your system motoring along longer. Budget-conscious buyers should stick

with at least 2 GB of RAM on your laptop - any lower and we're talking about netbooks, not laptops. For those desiring an all-purpose laptop, a minimum of 4 GB of RAM should be good enough for handling multimedia, entertainment and casual gaming, apart from everyday tasks.

In case you want to upgrade your laptop's RAM later, ensure that you double-check the maximum clock timings supported on your laptop's RAM. While buying

two sticks instead of one, don't buy RAM from different manufacturers; stick with only one manufacturer to save a good amount of troubleshooting time. Ideally, buy two RAM sticks which have the same manufacturer, clock setting, capacity, etc.

Hard drive

If there's one thing to be glad about personal computing and technology in general today is that storage costs have dropped a lot. Cost per GB is the best it's ever been and is expected to go down even further in the coming months. This is good news for budget-conscious laptop buyers because it eases their woes a bit. Having said that, opting for a fatter, faster hard drive is still going to eat into your budget and be more expensive than buying a slower hard drive with less space. Settle for a 160GB or 250GB hard drive with a 5400RPM spin speed - which is still the de-facto standard on most budget notebooks - instead of lusting for that 320GB drive spinning at 7200 RPM, unless you really require it.

Don't even think about SSDs. They're unfortunately still out-of-range for all budget and most all-purpose laptops even today. Though SSD prices, too, are witnessing significant price drops, they're ideal for high-end performance laptops and premium ultraportable laptops. In a couple of years, SSDs available on a budget laptop selling for ₹30,000 to ₹35,000 should become a tangible dream, going by the massive price drops in existing storage drives.



Buying an older generation processor makes perfect sense for a budget laptop to keep its price down